

CONTENT PLAYBOOK

Updated as of 12 Aug 2025

WRITING GOALS AND PRINCIPLES

Your content affects how the CPF Board is portrayed and perceived by users. Be sensitive to the needs of both citizens and the government.

The overarching core goal for CPF is to help citizens retire with confidence. Convey this intent by delivering content that **guides, educates, and empowers**.

1. Guide

Make the journey of understanding CPF easy. Lead users through information in a logical way, so they can accomplish tasks and actions with clarity. Keep your content:

- **Clear, concise, and consistent:** Use simple words and sentences. Organise content in a way that can be easily understood and scanned at a glance. Keep it consistent across the website.
- **Useful and practical:** Understand the topic you are writing about. If you cannot make sense of the content yourself, a user will not be able to either.
- **Straightforward and instructional:** Ask yourself: What purpose does this serve? Help users navigate the information flow and show them how to do the things they need to do.

2. Educate

Give users what they need to know, not what you want to market. Present basic information along with opportunities to access more complex information, if so desired. Remember to:

- **Be mindful and inclusive:** Users do not have access to all the information you have. You are the expert, but do not patronise your users. Communicate with them and place yourself in their shoes.
- **Keep content factual and succinct:** The online space is not equipped for voluminous and dense content. Feature key information upfront and keep related subtopics and explanations interlinked.
- **Make difficult topics easy to understand:** Do not be afraid to tell users if you know a topic can be confusing. It is our job to convert complexity into simplicity. Use jargon-free language, provide context, use examples, compare, and contrast.

3. Empower

Use language that informs and encourages citizens to make the most of our policies and services. Content should:

- **Decode and demystify:** Your content should always clarify actions and not make things more obscure. Be diligent with your word choice and write in terms that most people can relate to. Use visual aids to clarify how something works, when it is appropriate.
- **Alleviate uncertainty and fear:** Chances are, people do not know CPF policies well. Moreover, there are definite perceptions around the subject being too complicated and inaccessible. Help users understand that CPF is here to explain and talk them through the process of making informed decisions.

- **Be direct:** Focus on the strengths of CPF and understand its place in the lives of our citizens. When something impacts the way a CPF scheme or service performs, the users deserve to know. Do not hide clauses and caveats.

VOICE

The CPF voice embodies and expresses our organisation's personality and values. It is an important measure that affects how users perceive CPF. Adopt a voice that is **confident, respectful, honest, and human**.

1. Confident

We are a reliable, efficient, and trustworthy government entity that is focused and socially responsible. Speaking with confidence shows the depth of our leadership and competence, inspires trust in our users.

Communicating in a confident voice means:

- Being plain spoken and direct
- Imparting expertise with single-mindedness and clarity
- Delivering well-defined advice that can be easily put into action

✓ "CPF can help you remain independent in your old age with our comprehensive savings schemes."

2. Respectful

We are the expert and authority in our domain, but we are not condescending.

Speak to users in the way we want to be spoken to. Writing in a respectful voice means:

- Reserving judgement
- Being mindful of potential sensitivities
- Avoiding ambiguity and refraining from exaggerated claims and over-promises

✗ "Life expectancy in Singapore is expected to cross 90 in the future. As such, we may not have enough savings to meet our living expenses. That is why building up your CPF savings is more important than ever."

✓ "As we all will probably live longer, we will need a steady stream of income to meet living expenses."

3. Honest

Be open and authentic. Use the CPF content experience to build meaningful relationships that are grounded in sincerity.

Communicating honestly demonstrates transparency and trustworthiness to our users. This means:

- Having a genuine understanding of the user's aspirations and challenges
- Being forthright and providing reasons for actions
- Listening actively and encouraging user feedback when it is appropriate

✓ "After listening to feedback from our members, the Retirement Sum Scheme (RSS), will now last up to age 90 at most, instead of age 95."

4. Human

We are warm and accessible, but not unprofessional and inappropriate.

Writing in a human voice helps our users perceive the real people and processes behind our policies and words. This means:

- Considering the user's state of mind
- Being empathetic and connecting with our users' pain points
- Writing in an active voice that is conversational but not sloppy

✓ "Planning for retirement? Use our CPF LIFE Estimator to calculate how much you'll need for greater peace of mind."

TONE

CPF website users are likely to be citizens and residents of Singapore who need information about the government's social security system. It is crucial to Adopt a tone of voice that can consistently connect with this wide audience from all walks of life.

1. Positive tone

The positive tone is generally recommended as it is usually clearer and more concise than the negative.

2. Negative tone

Use the negative tone only for matters of regulations and compliance, e.g. content for employers.

✓ You can use your MediSave for assisted conception procedures up to a lifetime limit of \$15,000.

✗ You cannot use more than \$15,000 from your MediSave for assisted conception procedures.

3. Options vs obligations

Use "can" to describe user actions that are optional. Do not use "may" as the meaning is ambiguous in general usage.

✓ You can use your CPF savings to pay for your house.

✗ You may use your CPF savings to pay for your house.

Use "must" to describe user actions that are mandatory. Do not use "shall" as the meaning is ambiguous in general usage.

✓ Your employer must contribute to your CPF accounts.

✗ Your employer shall pay CPF contribution for employees.

Exercise your judgement on when to use each word, especially in situations where the user's actions are dependent on certain e-Service guidelines and fine print.

4. Avoid overpromising

Try to avoid words and phrases that can translate as gimmicky, over-demanding, and over-promising.

✓ Lead a better life in retirement.

✗ Live your best retirement life.

✓ Greater peace of mind.

✗ Absolute peace of mind.

5. Writing for employers

While content for employers may be more technical and functional, it is important for the tone to remain consistent. When writing,

- Always put the user first
- Ensure content is straightforward and easy to understand
- Use a recognisable tone of voice for consistency throughout the entire digital experience

✓ As an employer, you have a legal obligation to pay CPF contributions correctly and promptly for your employees. Non-compliance of CPF contributions is an offence.

ACTIVE VS PASSIVE VOICE

Use active voice whenever possible. It is easier to read and makes your message clearer and more direct. This is especially important when writing instructions or labels that support user actions.

Use passive voice when:

- Presenting neutral options rather than recommending an action.

✓ Withdrawals can be made at any time. (passive voice presents the option neutrally)

✗ You can withdraw your CPF at any time. (active voice can gg like a nudge/recommendation)

- Specifying the subject of a sentence that is not the actor.

✓ Your Basic Healthcare Sum is adjusted yearly until you reach age 65. (subject of sentence is "Your Basic Healthcare Sum")

✗ The CPF Board adjusts your Basic Healthcare Sum yearly until you reach age 65. (subject of sentence is "The CPF Board" instead)

- Mentioning a third party

✓ Your employer is required to make CPF contributions at the rate applicable to you. (passive voice allows mention of only two parties: the employer and the reader)

✗ The CPF Board requires your employer to make CPF contributions at the rate applicable to you. (active voice will require mention of CPF Board, which is unnecessary)

PRONOUNS

Write the way you speak. When referring to users, generally apply the second person pronoun. Note that use of pronouns in labels are subject to additional guidelines.

1. First person (plural): We, us, our

When to use

- When referring to CPF as a brand or organisation

Why use

- To establish a relatable tone of voice

✓ Your journey with us begins

2. First person (singular): I, me, my

When to use

- When writing questions for frequently asked questions (FAQs)

Why use

- To establish a relatable tone of voice

✓ How do I know the status of my application?

3. Third person: They, them, it

When to use

- To refer to users in an objective and gender-neutral manner

Why use

- To avoid awkward constructions such as he/she and she/he
- To distinguish 3rd parties from the user, which uses 2nd person

✗ Your family member, who is a co-owner of your flat, may use his/her Ordinary Account savings to pay your premium shortfall.

✓ Your family member, who is a co-owner of your flat, may use their Ordinary Account savings to pay your premium shortfall.

- To address the user in a socially sensitive context

✗ Your diagnosis date

✓ Date of diagnosis

- Avoid ungrammatical mixing of 2nd and 3rd person pronouns within a single sentence
- When introduce a new group of people, use the 3rd person in the first paragraph. For the second and subsequent sentences, use the 2nd person.

✓ CAYE is a nationwide initiative to help self-employed persons save for healthcare [3rd person]. Under CAYE, you are required to make a MediSave contribution whenever you earn a service fee [2nd person].

4. Mixing pronouns

Avoid awkward uses of both the first and second person within the same sentence.

✗ To view your CPF balances, go to my cpf Home.

✓ View your CPF balances.

✓ Go to my cpf Home.

CONTRACTIONS

Actively use contractions to give content a human voice.

These guidelines do not apply where formal writing is recommended:

- Infohub's news and CPF clarifies;
- Infohub's reports & statistics;
- Post-login dashboards and statements
- Calculators, forms and e-applications
- Corporate information about CPFB.

Common contractions that should be used:

- you're (you are) / you'll (you will) / you've (you have)
- we're (we are) / we'll (we will) / we've (we have)
- they're (they are) / they'll (they will) / they've (they have)
- it'll (it will)
- don't (do not)
- won't (will not)
- isn't (is not)
- can't (cannot)
- couldn't (could not)
- shouldn't (should not)
- wouldn't (would not)
- here's (here is)
- there's (there is)
- let's (let us)

Do not use contractions that are ambiguous:

- you'd (you had/would/could/should)

- we'd (we had/would/could/should)
- they'd (they had/would/could/should)
- it'd (it had/would/could/should)
- there'd (there had/would/could/should)
- there'll (there shall/will)

Do not use contractions for modal verbs

- would've (would have)
- could've (could have)
- should've (should have)

Do not use contractions of single words:

- ma'am (madam)
- 'til (until)

Do not use contractions used only in informal speech:

- ain't (are not)
- whatcha (what are you)
- gotta (got to)

Do not use contractions that include nouns:

- Your bank'll contact you (Your bank will contact you)

POLICY MESSAGING

1. Interest rates

Previous	Revised
Your CPF savings earn attractive and risk-free interest.	There is no need to emphasise that CPF offers "risk-free" interest as other banks also offer risk-free interest such as for fixed deposits. However, "risk-free" can be used when comparing against instruments that carry risk.
CPF currently distinguishes between the Extra Interest (EI) and Additional Extra Interest (AEI). The EI is explained as an extra 1% interest paid for a member's first \$60k in his CPF savings (with up to \$20k from OA) and the AEI is explained as a further 1% interest paid on a member's first \$30k for members above 55.	Extra interest should be explained in the following manner: • For members who are 55 years old and above, the Government pays an extra 2% interest on members' first \$30k, and 1% on next \$30k. For members below 55 years old, the Government pays an extra 1% on first \$60k.

2. Withdrawal from 55

Previous	Revised
Members are informed that they can withdraw their CPF savings at 55. Some members have the misimpression that withdrawals must be made at 55	Members can withdraw their CPF savings from 55. Members can withdraw CPF retirement savings to supplement CPF monthly payouts when needed. Members do not have to withdraw immediately. If they do not have an immediate need, it is better to leave it in their CPF accounts to earn attractive interest of up to 6% per year, instead of a bank account earning low interest. As and when the need arises, members can withdraw, whether in full or partially, as frequently as they like, and at any time after turning 55. These savings can be treated as a "rainy day fund" which members can draw upon anytime when needed. With PayNow, withdrawals will reach their bank account almost instantaneously. How much can members withdraw? From age 55, members can withdraw up to \$5,000 from their Special and Ordinary Accounts, or their CPF savings after they have set aside their Full Retirement Sum (FRS) in their Retirement Account (RA), whichever is higher. The FRS can be set aside fully with cash, or with cash (i.e. at least the Basic Retirement Sum) and property. From age 65, members born in 1958 or after also have the option to withdraw a lump sum of up to 20% of the savings in their Retirement Account at age 65. This includes the first \$5,000 that can be withdrawn from age 55.

3. CPF LIFE

Previous messaging	Revised messaging
CPF LIFE was introduced as an "annuity scheme".	For clarity, CPF LIFE should be described as a "national longevity insurance annuity scheme", for the following reasons: 1. National because it is government-run; 2. Longevity because this is what it insures against; 3. Insurance because it is a pooled scheme; and Annuity because it provides monthly payouts.
CPF LIFE monies are invested in Special Singapore Government Securities (SSGS), which are guaranteed by the AAA-rated Singapore Government, and provide high, risk-free returns of up to 6% p.a. Annuities offered by the private sector do not have access to these SSGS instruments.	CPF LIFE monies are guaranteed by the Singapore Government, and provide high, risk-free returns of up to 6% p.a. Annuities offered by the private sector are regulated by MAS but are not risk-free. Do not position CPF LIFE payouts as unmatchable. Sufficient to say it is very attractive for the premiums paid.
CPF LIFE plans were compared in terms of payouts and bequests (i.e. more for yourself/more for your loved one/more for the future).	To move away from comparing the three CPF LIFE plans in terms of payout levels. The message should be that members should consider the kind of retirement lifestyle they want, the retirement income they would need to maintain that lifestyle, and calculate the amount of Retirement Account savings that they would need. If there is a gap, then talk about what members can do to grow their retirement savings.
The difference in CPF LIFE plans was explained in terms of trade-offs between payouts and bequest. Instead, emphasis should be on payouts.	Do not highlight bequest as trade-off in comparison. Instead, with regard to that, state that members will always get back at least the savings put into CPF LIFE in the form of payouts and/or refund.

The Basic Plan is seen currently described as providing a lower payout but in fact it will also be "declining" (when members' combined CPF balances, including unused premiums, fall below \$60,000)	For Basic Plan, make clear that payouts will gradually decline due to less EI earned when combined balances fall below \$60k. Conceptualise payouts* as coming from the "CPF LIFE premium" that is deducted from the member's RA when they join CPF LIFE. When members pass away, they will receive the "CPF LIFE premium balance" (i.e. remaining CPF LIFE premium) and CPF savings. *Note: Basic Plan payouts are made from RA till one month before age 90 as only about 10-20% of RA is committed as CPF LIFE premium. From age 90, payouts will start from members' CPF LIFE premium.
Current explanation is that interest earned on CPF LIFE premiums are pooled to provide lifelong payouts for CPF LIFE members. We should improve on this for clearer communications.	Do not say that interest on CPF LIFE premiums earned goes to the pool. Instead, say that the interest earned on premiums pays for CPF LIFE members who live longer.
The "payout eligibility age" is often referred to when talking about CPF LIFE.	To stop using "payout eligibility age". To directly use "age 65".
Members are told that their beneficiaries will receive their unused annuity premium and RA savings as bequest. We should find a better way to explain the concept of "unused annuity premium".	

4. Housing Scheme

Previous	Revised
It has been explained to members that from 55, they could withdraw savings above their BRS with sufficient property pledge/charge. For members buying properties, the amount of CPF they can use to pay makes reference to the Valuation Limit (VL) and Withdrawal Limit (WL).	To stop using the term 'property pledge/charge' as members see it as a form of mortgage. To use "members from age 55 can withdraw savings above their BRS with property" instead. VL to be referred to "the lower of the purchase price or the valuation price of the property at the time of purchase." WL to be referred to "the maximum amount of OA savings owners can use for their property after setting aside BRS, which is up to another 20% of the lower of the purchase price or the valuation price of the property at the time of purchase." Positioning of Ordinary Account (OA): "Retirement" should be included as one of the uses of OA. This will help explain why members need to refund their OA when selling their property. In reality, a significant percentage of OA is used for retirement.

5. Dependants' Protection Scheme

Previous	Revised
DPS is referred as an opt out scheme for members. Members can also opt in to the scheme.	To stop using the terms "opt out" and "opt in" when referring to the scheme and replace "opt out" with "terminate" as it is more easily understood by the layman. Example: Members can terminate their DPS cover anytime.

6. Silver Housing Bonus

Previous	Revised
Silver Housing Bonus is explained as a cash bonus given to eligible homeowners for right-sizing and using part of the proceeds to top up their Retirement Account to increase retirement income.	It is not necessary for the SHB to highlight the topping-up of the RA. The focus of SHB should be on helping members reach the \$60,000 required to join CPF LIFE. The SHB is an incentive to encourage and help members attain the required \$60,000 in their RA to join CPF LIFE.

7. MediSave

(OSA-MA transfers, Medisave for SEPs, MA for MSL and CSL, VC- MA for SEPs)

Previous	Revised
Some terms involving the use of MA that are commonly used need to be rephrased to prevent misrepresentation. MediSave use is referred to as a MediSave "claim" in public comms.	MediSave use should be termed as MediSave "withdrawals" instead to emphasise that MediSave belongs to the member; it is not a claim made to CPF. For example: The term "SEP MediSave liability" to be rephrased to "SEP mandatory MediSave contributions" to more accurately describe what it is. "Use of MA for healthcare insurance premiums" to be rephrased to "Use of MA for MediShield Life and CareShield Life" to differentiate the mainstream schemes from the private medical insurance schemes, as we want to promote the mainstream schemes over PMIS.

8. Yearly Statement of Account (YSOA)

Previous messaging	Revised messaging
Terms such as "credited" and "debited" are difficult for members to understand.	To replace with more commonly-used terms such as "savings" and "withdrawals".

PREFERRED TERMS

1. Preferred terms for policy descriptions

For clarity in content and messaging, please take note of these preferred terms.

Avoid	Use
Cash	See monies
Autumn of life	Retirement
Ring-fencing	Reserve
Setting aside	Reserve
Earmark	Reserve
Turn age 55	Turn 55
Turn 55 years old	Turn 55
Payout eligibility age	Age 65
Per year	Per annum
Property pledge or property charge	Members from age 55 can withdraw savings above their Basic Retirement Sum with property
Opt out	Terminate
SEP MediSave liability	Self-employed person mandatory MediSave contributions
Use of MediSave Account for healthcare insurance premiums	Use of MediSave Account for MediShield Life and CareShield Life
MediSave claims	MediSave withdrawals
Older workers	Seniors or senior workers
Credited/debited	Savings/withdrawn
Lumpsum	Lump sum

Monies	Cash: When referring to actual cash Grant: When referring to: a. monies given by the government directly into a member's account (e.g. a matching grant) b. monies paid to eligible Singapore Citizens or Permanent Residents in cash. Savings: When referring to CPF savings. Do not use "CPF monies"
Accumulated surplus	Reserves
Withdraw from CPF (when ex-Singapore Citizens and ex-Singapore Permanent Residents close their CPF accounts)	Transfer CPF savings to personal bank account

2. Preferred terms for labels (stop here)

When to use

- When writing questions for frequently asked questions (FAQs)

3. Third person: They, them, it

When to use

- To refer to users in an objective and gender-neutral manner

Name	Title	Date

LAST SECTION

Write the way you speak. When referring to users, generally apply the second person pronoun. Note that use of pronouns in labels are subject to additional guidelines.

4. First person (plural): We, us, our

When to use

- When referring to CPF as a brand or organisation

5. First person (singular): I, me, my

When to use

- When writing questions for frequently asked questions (FAQs)

6. Third person: They, them, it

When to use

- To refer to users in an objective and gender-neutral manner

Name	Title	Date

SH: Preferred terms for labels

To deliver a consistent user experience follow these conventions:

Account

- Capitalise "A" in "Account" when referring to each individual account (e.g. Ordinary Account/Retirement Account),
- Use the lowercase "a" when more than one account is mentioned (e.g. Ordinary and Special accounts).

Available

- Use "Available" or "Available amount" only to describe the user's own account balances or their personal limits.
- Do not apply "Available" to third parties, or to amounts that the user needs to pay or repay

x Available amount lender can receive from you

✓ Amount you can receive from lender

Claim

- See "withdraw".

Credit

- Do not use. See "savings".

Debit

- Do not use. See "withdraw".

Excess

- Use when describing amounts in excess of what is owed or required (e.g. excess MediSave contributions).

Health insurance

- Use when referring to insurance coverage under MediShield Life or an Integrated Shield Plan.
- Health insurance includes long-term care insurance coverage, i.e. CareShield Life, ElderShield, and related Supplements.
- See health insurance

History

- Use to refer to statements that describe transactions over user-defined period of time, such as the Transaction history and Contribution history. There is no need to use the term “statement” in the titles of such pages/products, as “history” already gives users sufficient context on what the page/product is about.

Less and Add

- Use "Less:" and "Add:" to aggregate items in a statement.
- Values labelled "Less:" label must use the negative sign.
- Consider using "Less:" for aggregated items only. Avoid prefixing a sequence of items with "Less:" , so that users can scan the statement more easily.
- Consider using accordions in conjunction with "Less:" and "Add:" to reduce page length.
- Grouping "Less:" and "Add:" items together. Avoid alternating between "Less:" and "Add:" in a single statement.

May

- Use “may” to convey possibility, e.g. The inflation rate may rise, We may contact you for more details.
- Avoid “may” when conveying instructions or presenting options to users as it is vague. Instead, use “should” when presenting a strong recommendation, and “can” when presenting an open set of choices.

Medical insurance

- Use when referring to insurance coverage under MediShield Life or an Integrated Shield Plan.
- Medical insurance excludes long-term care insurance coverage, e.g. CareShield Life, ElderShield, and related Supplements.
- See health insurance

Net

- Use "Net" to describe numbers total figures less specific deductions. See also "total" and "less"
- Where possible, net figures should be displayed together with total figures, to allow users to understand how the net figure was arrived. If this is not possible (e.g. the net figure is part of the dashboard summary), explain how the number was arrived using a tooltip or a hyperlink to the calculation breakdown

Outstanding

- Use when conveying the concept of cumulative amounts owed. Used together with "payable".

Payable

- Use when describing amounts that is due now and needs to be paid (e.g. Outstanding MediSave payable). Used together with "outstanding".

Payment

- Use payment to list items that are payable to a 3rd party that is not CPF, e.g. stamp duty.
- Avoid using "pay" and "payment" to describe deposits by users into their own or others' CPF accounts. Use transfer instead.
- Use "Payment for... <item_name>" to clarify the payment purpose.

Premium

- Use "premium" to describe payments for insurance policies that cover life, healthcare and home insurance policies.
- Singular "premium" should only be used for a single payment. In all other cases, use plural "premiums". E.g. annual premiums, premiums you pay for multiple policies and Supplements

Portal

- Use "portal" to refer to post-login destinations (e.g. member portal, employer portal, business partners portal).

Share

- Use for social media functionalities only.
- Do not use as substitute for "lend" ("Amount shared for education") or , "submit" ("Share contact details with CPF Board").

Saving

- Use for savings kept in a CPF account. Do not use "cash (in CPF account)" or "(CPF) monies".
- Use for the action taken by a CPF member to deposit savings into their CPF account. Do not use "credit" or "credited".

Total

- Use "Total" only when it is necessary, e.g. to describe a number as the final aggregate.

✗ The recipient's total income in the previous year cannot exceed \$4,000. ("Total" is superfluous and does not affect the sentence meaning.)

✓ The recipient's income in the previous year cannot exceed \$4,000

- When describing mathematical workings, it is not necessary to describe every addition of two or more numbers as a "total". Use "sum" instead.

✓ The sum of days in general and intensive care wards cannot exceed 99 days. (Example of a validation message where input in multiple input fields is checked to ensure that they do not add up to 100 or more)

✗ The total number of days of in a general ward and intensive care ward cannot exceed 99 days. ("Total" is superfluous and sounds more like a policy restriction than just a form-specific range limit.)

Withdraw

- Use only for situations where a) user is using their MediSave savings for healthcare bills. Do not use “claim” for MediSave withdrawals; b) user is transferring CPF savings to their bank account due to reduced life expectancy.
- Do not use for transfer of CPF savings to a bank account when a member closes their CPF account (i.e. they are leaving Singapore or West Malaysia).
- Do not use “debit” or “debited”.

SH: Branding

Correct	Incorrect
my cpf	• My CPF • my cpf • mycpf
Singpass	SingPass
Corppass	CorpPass
Singpass app	SingPass Mobile

Plain language

1. [Use plain language](#)
2. [Jargon](#)
3. [Words to avoid](#)
4. [Sentence constructions to avoid](#)

SH: Use plain language

All content published on the CPF website or any other related digital domains should be written in simple language.

In addition, there are certain rules of grammar and style we adopt to help keep our content consistent. These guidelines will not be relevant to everything, but you should always keep them in mind.

SH: Jargon

Always remember, users do not have knowledge about the technicalities the way you do. Strive to make your content as easy to understand as possible. If no common alternative exists, define the term for the user early on.

Example where jargon is unnecessary:

✗ The CPF Investment Scheme (CPFIS) gives you an option to invest your Ordinary Account (OA) and Special Account (SA) savings in a wide range of investments to enhance your retirement nest egg.

✓ The CPF Investment Scheme (CPFIS) lets you invest your CPF savings to build your retirement savings.

Example where jargon is unavoidable:

✓ Premiums in excess of your MediSave Life's available withdrawal limit have to be paid in cash.

SH: Words to avoid

Do not use long words when short words will do. Use familiar words that everyone can understand.

Avoid	Use
Persons	People
Whether or not	If
Within	In
Prior to	Before
Commence	Start
Utilise	Use
In regard to	About
Purchase	Buy
Assist	Help
Not different	Similar
Not many	Few

For more information, refer to the [Plain Language and Information Network \(PLAIN\)](#) for a comprehensive list of complex words and their substitutes.

SH: Sentence constructions to avoid

Double negatives

Avoid using double negatives as they are hard to understand and may confuse users.

✗ I do not want to unsubscribe.

✓ I want to subscribe.

Double verbs

Avoid the double-verb construction, e.g. "Apply for <action>".

✓ "Withdraw from Ordinary Account" or "Apply for withdrawal"

✗ "Apply for withdrawal from Ordinary Account"

Parenthetical plurals

Avoid the parenthetical plural "(s)". Use only when a variable number precedes the affected noun. If it must be used, the writer must check for subject-object agreement.

Dynamic value examples

✓ You are using your MediSave to pay for the MediShield Life premiums of 1 dependant(s). (bold text indicates the data value)

✗ Total you and your co-owner(s) can use (the dynamic value is not a part of this sentence fragment)

Static value examples

✗ You are using your MediSave to pay for the MediShield Life premiums of one dependant(s). ("one" is static and does not warrant a parenthetical plural)

✗ Your co-owner(s)' balances is included in the calculation. (incorrect subject-verb agreement)

✓ Your co-owner's(s') balance(s) is (are) included in the calculation. (correct subject-verb agreement)

✓ Your property's co-owners' balances are included in the calculation. (the parenthetical plural is omitted)

If any

"if any" is used when describing unlikely scenarios. It is interchangeable with a simple "if" statement.

✓ Errors, if any, should be reported to the CPF Board as soon as you find them.

✓ If you find any errors, you should report them to the CPF Board as soon as possible.

Do not use "if any" to describe scenarios that are equally likely or important. It is often not clear what "if any" is referring to.

✗ Remember to pay your monthly contributions, if any. (This sentence has multiple interpretations: "If you are required to pay monthly contributions, remember to..."; "If you have not paid your contribution this month, remember to..."; "If you have outstanding monthly contributions, remember to..."; "If you have not fully paid this month's contribution, remember to...")

✓ Remember to pay your monthly contributions. (assumes that reader is required to pay contributions)

✓ Participating members are required to pay monthly contributions. (contributions are required only from participating members)

Whichever is lower/the lower of

Use "Whichever is lower" and "the lower of" only when describing a formula with two variable caps. Do not use when one of the "caps" is a known value.

✗ Under MediShield Life, you will be able to claim the lower of \$1,200.00 per calendar year or 90% of the actual cost for your cancer drug-related services.

✓ Under MediShield Life, you can claim 90% of your bill for cancer drug-related services, up to \$1,200.00 per calendar year.

And/or

Use "and/or" only for legal or technical situations where it is important to clarify that when two conditions are jointly met (A and B), it is the same as when only one condition is met (only condition A or only B).

✓ Additional \$600 (MediSave withdrawal limit) for cancer drug services and/or cancer scans (This means \$600 is the withdrawal limit whether you use cancer drug services, cancer scans, or both. Use of both cancer drug services and cancer scans does not mean the limit can be doubled to \$1,200.)

In most cases, however, "and" is sufficient for clarity.

✓ Utilisation for cancer drug services and cancer scans: \$321.00 (This means \$321 was spent on "Cancer drug services and cancer scans", a single treatment category)

✗ Utilisation for cancer drug services and/or cancer scans: \$321.00 (This means cancer drug services and cancer scans are two separate categories, and it cannot be ascertained how the amount can be divided and categorised.)

Common mistakes

1. [By versus to](#)
2. [Top-up versus. top up](#)

SH: By versus to

Be mindful of the use of "by" versus "to" when referring to growth in sentences, as they mean different things.

✓ With a top-up of \$XX monthly, your Special Account savings can grow by more than \$XX,XXX over XX years.

SH: Top-up versus. top up

Where the term "top-up" is used as a noun, the hyphen separating the two words should be used. Examples:

- CPF top-ups will be matched dollar-for-dollar by the Government for Singaporeans aged 55 to 70.
- Make a cash top-up to your loved one's Special Account (SA) or Retirement Account (RA) to enjoy up to \$7,000 of tax relief per annum.

Where the term "top up" is used as a verb, no hyphenation is required.

Examples:

- Top up with cash or transfer your CPF savings to help grow your retirement funds.
- Get tax relief for topping up your Special or Retirement Account.

Spelling

British English spelling is used across all our communications unless the spelling is part of the brand or scheme name.

In situations where you may be unsure about the correct British spelling, use the spell checker on Microsoft Word or an [online spell checker](#).

Capitalisation

Except proper nouns and institution names, use sentence case for all copy. This includes titles and labels. Do not use block capitals for large amounts of text or sentences.

General proper nouns

- Malaysia Citizen
- Singapore Permanent Resident
- Singapore Citizen

Account names

- Ordinary Account
- Special Account
- MediSave Account
- Retirement Account
- Post-Secondary Education Account

Scheme names (includes non-CPF)

- Additional Premium Support
- Care and Support and Solidarity Payment
- CareShield Life
- Contribute-As-You-Earn
- Drive and Save
- Edusave
- ElderShield
- Home Protection Scheme
- Integrated Shield Plan
- MediShield Life
- MediSave Grant for Newborns
- Retirement Sum Scheme
- Retirement Top-Up Scheme
- Self-Employed Scheme
- Silver Support Scheme
- Workfare
- Workfare Income Supplement

- Workfare Income Supplement Scheme
- Workfare Special Payment

Others

- 5-Year MediSave Top-up
- Additional Premium Support
- Additional Wage
- Contribute-As-You-Earn Matched MediSave Contributions
- CPF LIFE Bonus
- CPF Top-up (Bicentennial Bonus)
- Deferment Bonus
- Direct Debit
- Direct Debit Arrangement
- Extra Interest
- GST Voucher
- Housing Grant
- Merdeka Generation MediSave
- NS HOME Awards
- Ordinary Wage
- Pioneer Generation MediSave
- Premium Subsidies
- Training Commitment Award
- Self-Employed Person Income Relief
- Supplement
- SG Bonus 2018
- Silver Support
- Workfare Bicentennial Bonus
- Yearly Statement of Account

Abbreviations

1. [When to use](#)
2. [Component-specific rules](#)
3. [When not to use](#)

SH: When to use

The following terms do not need to be spelled out in full, whether used as body content, section headings, navigation labels, or CTAs.

Selected scheme names

- CPF LIFE

Organisation names

- CPF

Common acronyms

- ATM
- AXS
- FAQ
- GST

Brand names

- Acronyms should be used if it is part of a brand name. Check the relevant official source for correct representation of the brand.
- Brand identity rules supercedes the "when not to use" list, e.g. "SG Bonus 2018"

Other use cases

- Any acronym not listed above must be spelled out before use. Usage must also conform with [component-specific rules](#).
- If a term is used only once on a page, it need not be spelled out, even if an acronym or abbreviation is available.

SH: Component-specific rules

Navigation

- Navigation elements (navigation titles, breadcrumbs, anchor links, menu items) cannot use abbreviations and acronyms unless they are in the positive list.

Headers

- Page, card, and section headings cannot use abbreviations and acronyms unless they are in the positive list.
- If an acronym must be used, do not use full name (acronym) in the header. Instead, use full name in the header, and full name (acronym) in the paragraph immediately following the header.

CTAs

- Buttons and navigation links cannot use abbreviations and acronyms unless they are in the positive list.

Body content

- In general, acronyms or abbreviations should be used in these situations:
 - When the acronym or abbreviation is just as recognisable (or more) than the fully spelt term Body.
E.g. ATM, CPF LIFE. See the positive list for a full list of acronyms that can be used without defining them prior.
 - When the acronym or abbreviation is in current use for branding and public communications.
E.g. CPF LIFE. See the positive list for a full list of acronyms that can be used without defining them prior.
 - When the space is limited.

E.g. tables, data labels

The default method of explaining acronyms is <full spelling> (<acronym>): spell out the term in full, followed by the acronym in parentheses.

- This definition should be positioned as close to the first instance acronym as possible. E.g. if an acronym's first instance is at the bottom of a page, avoid placing the definition at the top of the page, as the user is likely to forget it by the time they reach the bottom.
- If an acronym is used in a table, it should be spelled out immediately before or after the table.
- If an acronym is used in a data label, it should be spelled out in a tooltip, a help text, or an immediate paragraph.
- Acronyms must be defined once on every page.

Note that content that is too technical for the target audience is a deviation from Instruction Manual guidelines. (See [IM 10.1/G17](#)) Consider rewriting without using jargon.

- When the acronym is used in a 3rd party official document.

E.g. MRI/CT scan

Some user journeys start in a document or web page from another government agency, bank or another third party. If the source primarily uses an acronym, we should follow as well.

Modals and tooltips

- Acronyms must be defined at least once if used in a modal or tooltip. The definition must be provided even if it has previously been defined on the main page.

Tabs

- Avoid defining acronyms within a tabbed section. As far as possible, define the acronym before it occurs in the tabbed section.
- If an acronym is first defined in a tabbed section, it must be defined again when it is used in subsequent tabs, or in a subsequent section. This is so that users do not have to check across tabs to find explanations for acronyms.

SH: When not to use

Avoid using the following terms, even with explanations. This is to avoid cluttering the website with unnecessary and unfamiliar jargon.

- SE (Self-employed)
- SG (Singapore)
- SC (Singapore Citizen)
- PR (Permanent Resident)
- AWL (Available withdrawal limit)
- ANB (Age next birthday)
- EI (Extra Interest)
- AEI (Additional Extra Interest)

If there is insufficient space, designers and/or copywriters must find a workaround. For technical workarounds, refer to the [WCAG guidelines for technical solutions](#).

Common workaround solutions:

- Replace acronym if it is not necessary (e.g. use "You" instead of "The SEP").
- Define the acronym in a proximate design element, e.g. tooltip.

For more information, refer to [WCAG SC 3.1.4](#).

Punctuations and symbols

1. [Serial Comma \(or Oxford Comma\)](#)
2. [Semicolon](#)
3. [Quotation Marks \(Double Inverted Commas\)](#)
4. [Parentheses](#)
5. [Hyphens](#)
6. [Ampersand \(&\)](#)
7. [Forward Slash \(/\)](#)
8. [Backward Slash \(\\)](#)
9. [At Sign \(@\)](#)

SH: Serial Comma (or Oxford Comma)

In a series of items, use the serial comma before the conjunction "and" when the second-last and last items can be misinterpreted as a single item.

SH: Semicolon

Avoid semicolons. When linking clauses or ideas, use commas or start a new sentence.

✓ MediSave is a national medical savings scheme, MediShield Life is a basic healthcare insurance scheme which you can fund with MediSave.

✗ MediSave is a national medical savings scheme; MediShield Life is a basic healthcare insurance scheme which you can fund with MediSave.

SH: Quotation Marks (Double Inverted Commas)

Use quotation marks when:

- Referencing labels, and values
- Referring to direct quotations

✓ This date must be later than your "Policy start date".

✓ Log in to the HDB website to obtain your "Date Applied" or "Date of Application".

SH: Parentheses

Use parentheses for additional explanatory content in prose. If the content is essential for understanding, integrate it as part of the sentence.

✓ A CPF nomination allows CPF members to specify who will receive their CPF savings, and how much each nominee will receive, upon their demise.

✗ A CPF nomination allows CPF members to specify who will receive their CPF savings (and how much each nominee will receive) upon their demise.

SH: Hyphens

Use hyphens for conjoined words, but avoid three-word phrases.

✓ cash top-up

✗ dollar-cost-averaging

SH: Ampersand (&)

Always use "and" instead of the ampersand. Only use the ampersand for names/proper names or stylised design such as logos.

✓ healthcare and housing needs

✗ healthcare & housing needs

SH: Forward Slash (/)

Use only as separator. Use as headings and labels only if it helps with scanning and doesn't hinder readability.

✓ Courses / seminars

Do not use in place of "or" or "and" unless space is limited.

✓ CareShield or ElderShield

✓ CareShield and ElderShield

SH: Backward Slash (\)

Do not use the backward slash (\).

SH: At Sign (@)

Use the at mark only for email addresses and social media handles.

✓ Visit us at our CPF Service Centres.

✗ Visit us @ our CPF Service Centres.

Numbers and measurements

- [Cardinal numbers](#)
- [Ordinal numbers](#)
- [Ranges](#)
- [Currency](#)
- [Telephone numbers](#)
- [Percentage symbol \(%\)](#)

SH: Cardinal numbers

Use a comma to separate numbers that are four digits or more. Insert a non-breaking space between the numeral and the unit of measurement (exception: all symbols: \$, %, °)

✓ \$5,000

✓ 5,000 g

Spell out one to nine. Use numerals for 10, 11 and so on (see [IM 3.2/G21](#)).

✓ CPF members and employers are two main users of our digital platforms and services.

Spell out large numbers (see [IM 3.2/G21](#)).

✓ 23 million

Exceptions:

- Headlines, where the numerical form is effective in drawing in the reader
- CPF service standards
- CPF forms and e-forms applications.
- When space is limited (e.g. lists and data labels)

✓ 5 Ways to Support Your Parents' Retirement

✓ 3 working days required for processing

SH: Ordinal numbers

Spell out first to ninth. Use numerals for 10th, 11th and so on (see [IM 3.2/G21](#)). Use superscript for ordinals.

✓ First

✓ Second

✓ Third

✓ Fourth

✓ 55th birthday

SH: Ranges

"Between... and" and "From... to" are acceptable formats for presenting ranges of values.

Use "to" when presenting numerical ranges. Do not use dash as it may confuse blind users--screen reader software cannot distinguish number ranges from negative values.

✓ The Home Protection Scheme covers members between the ages of 21 and 65.

✓ 1 to 1,000

x 1 – 1,000

SH: Currency

Do not specify a currency type (e.g. SGD) unless necessary.

Do not include decimal points if the figure displayed is intended to be an estimate.

For both account balances and transfers, use "\$0" when the data value is zero. Do not use dash or "N/A".

✓ \$850

✓ \$18.99

SH: Telephone numbers

Use non-breaking spaces to break telephone numbers into four-digit blocks.

For numbers starting with 1800, use four-digit blocks for the start and end.

For international calling, always precede the number with the country code.

✓ 6226 3866

✓ 1800 226 3866

✓ +65 6226 3866

SH: Percentage symbol (%)

Use the percentage symbol instead of spelling out "percent".

Make sure that the symbol is the same size and font of the preceding number.

Do not include spaces between the symbol and the preceding number.

✓ 45%

Dates and time

1. Dates

2. Time

SH: Dates

Use the Date Month Year format for dates. Use non-breaking spaces to prevent parts of the date from wrapping to the next line.

✓ 12 March 2022

x 12 March
2022

Use day ordinals only for recurring dates. Do not use them for simple dates.

✓ 15th of every month

x 12th March 2022

For dashboards and statements, use the three-character abbreviated form ("Mon", "Tue", "Jan", "Oct") to keep labels short and layouts fluid.

For general use, use the full spelling for months and days of weeks. Abbreviate dates only when using components with space constraints, e.g. tables, banner carousels, date stamps, widgets.

If two dates are related in a sentence and occur in the same year, the year should only appear on the second date.

✓ Apply online between 1 August and 30 September 2022

For date ranges, use "between <date> and <date>" and "from <date> to <date>".

✓ Apply online between 1 August and 30 September 2022

SH: Time

When writing about time, use the 12-hour HH:MM clock format.

- Use numerals. Show ante or post meridian as "am" and "pm".
- Do not have any spaces between the number and "am" or "pm".
- Do not use an additional ":00" for times on the hour.
- The format MM:SS can be used for countdown timers.

✓ 10am to 10:30am

✓ Due to inactivity, your session will expire in 01:55. Do you need more time?

Tone and structure

1. [Structure](#)
2. [Tone](#)

SH: Structure of error messages

Error messages should be expressed in simple language that is familiar to users. It should accurately state the problem and constructively suggest a solution.

A complete error message should include three elements: Problem, Explanation, Rectification. However, if the problem and explanation are implied in the rectification, it is sufficient to provide the rectification.

✗ This date is invalid. Enter a valid date.

✓ Enter a valid date.

Do not overcommunicate the problem. If the problem is complex and cannot be meaningfully explained in a small space, apologise and make clear it is not the user's fault.

✓ Sorry, something went wrong on our end.

SH: Tone of error messages

When writing error messages:

- Use "sorry" only when apologising for issues not caused by the user (e.g. API errors). Avoid apologising for user errors.
 - Use "please" judiciously as it unnecessarily lengthens copy. In some contexts, it may sound like a command rather than sounding polite.
 - Use "For help" instead of "For assistance". Assistance is reserved for describing financial assistance.
 - Avoid wording that causes unnecessary anxiety in the user.
-

Input validation messages

Input validation messages are single lines of text displayed below the input field when the user's input does not meet formatting or range requirements. These guidelines do not cover scenarios where users' input are checked against backend records—those require customisation based on business requirements.

1. [Tone](#)
2. [Formatting validation](#)
3. [Range validation](#)
4. [Mandatory input](#)

SH: Tone

Avoid wording that unnecessarily alarms the user.

✗ Invalid email address detected

✓ Enter a valid email address (e.g. yourname@email.com)

Use "For help" instead of "For assistance". Assistance is reserved for describing financial assistance.

Do not overcommunicate. If the problem is complex and cannot be meaningfully explained in a small space, apologise and make clear it is not the user's fault.

✓ Sorry, something went wrong on our end.

SH: Formatting validation

For formatting validation, use one of the following templates:

- Wrong phone number format: Enter a valid Singapore telephone number (8 digits).
- Wrong email address format: Enter a valid email address (e.g. yourname@email.com).
- Wrong date format: Enter a valid date (dd/mm/yyyy).
- Wrong NRIC format: Enter a valid NRIC number (e.g. S1234567A)

SH: Range validation

For range validation, use one of the following templates:

- Enter a value from \$500 to \$5,000,000.
- Enter a value from 1 to 99 years.

- Enter a value from 1% to 100%.
- Enter a value of \$1 or more.
- Enter a value less than \$29,501.00.
- Enter a date less than 6 months from today.
- Enter a date earlier than your "Policy start date".
- Enter a date later than the "As at date" of your outstanding loan amount.

SH: Mandatory input

When input is missing from mandatory fields, use the message for formatting or range validation. In cases where formatting or range validation is not applicable, e.g. name fields, use "This field is mandatory."

Search engines

1. [General guidelines](#)
2. [Title tags](#)
3. [Meta descriptions](#)

SH: General guidelines

There are some simple ways to make the CPF website content more discoverable.

- Include terms and phrases used by your audience in your content, especially headings and links. Check with the call centre team or web analytics reports to identify such phrases.
- Be deliberate and strategic with the inclusion of keywords. Understand the user intent behind keywords before including them in content
- Target two to three keywords per page. Do not attempt to pad content with variations of the same keywords.
- Write naturally, as a human writer would. Do not attempt to game search engine algorithms by stuffing your content with keywords.
- CPF preferred terms are not necessarily keywords used by people for search. If CPF's preferred terms are not commonly used or understood, you need to add keywords to your content.

For more on SEO keywords, check the SEO guidelines.

SH: Title tags

The title tag is displayed at the top of the browser and as the header in listings within the Search Engine Results Pages (SERPs). When writing title tags, remember:

- The title tag must be unique, otherwise it will confuse users when results with identical titles appear in the search engine.
- Put important keywords first.
- Keep the length short. The optimal length for a title tag is **50-60 characters**. Longer titles will be cut off and not be displayed properly.

- Exclude stop words ("and", "or"), pronouns and unnecessary terms wherever possible.
- Put "CPF" at the start of the title, separated by a vertical bar. E.g. CPFB | Guide to retirement planning

SH: Meta descriptions

When writing meta descriptions, remember:

- Keep it brief, up to a maximum of 160 characters.
 - If the title tag captures the attention of users, the meta description should entice them to click through.
 - Include the most important keyword first, followed by other less important keywords (if applicable).
 - Include a call-to-action.
-

Images and graphics

1. [Image design](#)
2. [Alt text](#)

SH: Image design

Do not mimic user interface elements, such as buttons, scroll bar and title bars. Users may mistake the illustration to be an interactive element.

SH: Alt text

Alternative text ("alt text" or "alt tags") are text used to label images in HTML. They are used by search engines to index content, and by people who navigate apps and websites on their phones and computers using screen reading features.

SH: When to use alt text vs captions

Alt text does not substitute captions. When necessary, always supplement images with visible standard captions in addition to alt text.

- Infographics and charts: Describe trends, key numbers, and the conclusion.
- Stock photography and images: Use a brief description. If the image's purpose is just visual interest and does not provide information, consider use the null alt text (double quote marks or "") to indicate that the illustration has no informative value.
- Decorative illustrations: Do not write alt text as it will confuse search engines and blind users of screen reader software. Use the null alt text (double quote marks or "") to indicate that the illustration has no informative value.

Learn more about alt text best practices from the [Shopify Polaris design system](#).

SH: How to write alt text

- Keep the alt text to within 100 to 125 characters.
- Do not include "image of," "picture of", etc. in alt text.

- Do not lift image descriptions directly from image stock libraries. Edit the alt text to ensure it complies with content playbook guidelines.

For images with persons in it, there is no need to describe the race.

✗ Asian Chinese family of three generations seated at park and playing with bubble gun (descriptions of race are sensitive and unnecessary; bubble gun is not a CPF keyword and irrelevant to context)

✓ Family of three generations seated at park

Content design

1. [Prioritise important information](#)
2. [Inverted pyramid](#)
3. [Chunks and blocks](#)

SH: Prioritise important information

Important details should be positioned at the top of the page. ([IM 3.2/G18a](#)) Use the user story as the basis for deciding the order of content.

1. Content that describes user goals and directly facilitates user task completion should be presented at the top of the page.
2. Content that supports user task completion, e.g. tips, comparisons, tables, should be inserted at appropriate positions on the page.
3. Content that are "good to have", i.e. they do not help users to complete their goals, they are infrequently accessed by users, should be omitted from a page.

Plan your content by translating user stories into content: <https://medium.com/pragma-partners/how-to-design-content-that-works-7c7b66b25276>.

SH: Inverted pyramid

Use the inverted pyramid to structure content at the page- and card level. The inverted pyramid helps users by:

1. Helps the user scan information quickly by putting the most important information first
2. Helps the user identify what they can/should after reading
3. Helps the user to grasp the content quickly by improving flow and deprioritising the least important information

How to write in the Inverted Pyramid style:

1. Identify call to action, where it is appropriate to lead with it.
2. Identify the hook for user's attention
3. Identify your key points and rank information into primary and secondary importance
4. Write concisely
5. Start the story with the main point
6. End with the call to action

7. Consider adding a summary

SH: Chunks and blocks

Break the content down into chunks and blocks so it is easier to skim, understand, and remember.

A few commonly used methods of putting text into chunks and blocks are:

- Short paragraphs with some white space to separate them
 - Short sentences (around 50-70 characters; SiteImprove defines sentences exceeding 20 words as "long")
 - Clear headings and subheads
 - Bulleted lists
-

Lists

1. [Alphanumeric lists](#)
2. [Bullet lists](#)

SH: Alphanumeric lists

- Use numbered lists when you need to convey a priority, hierarchy, or sequence between list items.
- Helps users to follow procedures, steps, sequences, and instructions more easily
- If a numeric header is used, alphabets or Roman numerals are recommended for subsections to enhance clarity for readers.
- Roman headers should only be used for non-tiered lists.

SH: Bulleted lists

- Use bulleted lists to help users quickly scan through a list of items
 - Keep between 5 to 8 items in each list. Avoid creating bullet lists that comprise only 1 item.
 - Keep to a maximum of 2 levels of bullet points (primary and secondary).
 - Do not use bulleted lists if the list needs to convey a specific order or sequence. Use an alphanumeric list instead.
-

Tables

Use tables for organising structured content, such as sets of numerals, attributes, time, etc.

- If it is possible to organise the content both as a table and a list, use a list instead. Tables are more difficult to design and maintain.
- Always check tables on the mobile layout before publishing. Tables that cannot be viewed easily on a mobile screen must be redesigned.
- If a series of tables are required within a single content card, each table must include a table caption.

- Avoid creating large or complex tables (more than 7 columns or 15 rows) as they cannot be viewed easily on a mobile screen. Split large tables into a series of smaller ones with appropriate table captions.

Layout guidelines

- Text that exceeds cell width will wrap to the next line.
 - Text values should be left-aligned and vertically centred within a cell.
 - For columns that contains numerical values only, header and values should be right-aligned and vertically centred within a cell.
 - Use alternating styles to visually separate the rows and help users compare data when scrolling.
 - Keep text links outside of tables, or within table values only. Do not use hyperlink text for header values.
 - As far as possible, orientate tables so that values can be read left to right. Vertically oriented tables are less accessible to screen reader users.
 - Do not fix the header column if the longest cell value exceeds 25 characters. Users will be unable to access columns to the right of the column in a mobile screen (portrait mode).
 - Do not attempt to fit more than one value in each cell, separated by line breaks. Row values that appear lined up on a desktop may misalign when viewed on a mobile screen.
-

Links and buttons

1. [Calls to action](#)
2. [Links](#)

SH: Calls-to-action

The call-to-action (CTA) is a link and the focal point of a content card, a page section, or an entire page. CTA can take the form of a text link or a button link.

When to use CTA (button or text) vs an inline link

CTA have more visual prominence on the screen than a link. As a rule,

- Use a CTA to draw the user's attention towards an action (e.g. submit a form, confirm a payment) or to navigate to an eservice, dashboard or calculator.
- Use an inline link to navigate users to another information page

Button vs text CTA

- There are two types of CTA: the button CTA and the text link CTA.
- When choosing between a button or text CTA, always consider using the button first if a CTA is required. The button CTA has better contrast and visibility than the text CTA, and is recommended for most use cases.
- However, when there are more than 3 CTA on a single page (e.g. a listing of eservices), consider using text CTA only so that the screen is not filled with buttons, which are distracting and affects the user's ability to scan content and make navigation decisions.

How to write labels for CTA

- As a rule, CTA should be written as verbs and not nouns.

✓ [View retirement dashboard](#)

✗ [Retirement dashboard here](#)

Exception: If the CTA label exceeds the component character limit of 24, you can omit the verb.

✗ [View late CPF member dashboard](#) (28/24 characters)

✓ [Late CPF member dashboard](#) (23/24 characters)

- Ensure that the CTA wording matches the destination page heading (or section heading, if the link is to a page anchor).

✗ [Check your transfer limit](#) (in this example, page name is “Retirement dashboard”, not “Transfer limit”. Within the destination page, there is also neither a section nor any other label called “transfer limit”)

✓ [View retirement dashboard](#)

- Always keywords. Do not use nondescript link text. (required for SEO, [IM8 section 3.2/S17](#) and [WCAG F89](#))

✗ [Click here](#)

✓ [Make a CPF nomination now](#)

✓ [Visit <website name>](#) (for external websites)

- Always use unique labels for CTA. Do not display two CTA with the same label on a single page unless they perform the same action.
- Both text and button CTA are limited to a character limit of 24 characters. If the text is too long, try the following:
 - Include an ARIA label to ensure accessibility to blind users and compliance with [Instruction Manual 8 section 3.2/S17](#). (See [WCAG ARIA8](#) for examples of ARIA labels)
- Avoid acronyms in CTAs. ([WCAG SC 3.1.4](#)).

References: [NN/g recommendations on Learn more links](#), [Medium article on links vs buttons](#)

SH: Links

- Ensure that the link text matches the destination page heading (or section heading, if the link is to a page anchor). Refer to [Lighthouse SEO guideline](#)
- Ensure that hyperlinked text is self-contained and makes sense without the rest of the sentence. Besides improving SEO, this will improve accessibility. Refer to [WCAG H30](#) for details.

✓ [Register for the workshop](#) before 5 September 2022

✗ You can register [online](#)

✗ [Click here](#) to register

- As a rule, link only the nouns/objects. Do not include the verb and the article.

✓ Retrieve your current Ordinary Account savings

Exception: include the verb in the hyperlink text if the noun portion has insufficient context for blind users.

✗ Retrieve your current Ordinary Account savings

Context: The link's action is to retrieve the OA savings. Linking only "current Ordinary Account savings" would mislead blind users into thinking this link takes them to a different page for displaying current Ordinary Account savings, instead of the intended action.

- Avoid using acronyms in links. (**WCAG SC 3.1.4**)
- Do not insert URLs as link text. Long URLs affect page layout, especially on mobile devices, as well as accessibility.

✓ Consider making a CPF nomination

✗ Find out about CPF nominations by going to <https://www.cpf.gov.sg/member/account-services/providing-for-your-loved-ones/making-a-cpf-nomination>

Exceptions:

- When it is necessary to describe a change in a site's web address.
- When displaying an URL equivalent of a QR code, for accessibility reasons.
- Do not use link text that will fail automated audits. (**Lighthouse SEO guideline**)

✗ click here

✗ click this

✗ go

✗ here

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